It is important to say a few more words on what this book is and what it is not. As noted above, it is about four key drivers of conflict between the two Asian giants. It is not a book about the latest developments in India–China relations, in particular the events in Ladakh since April–May 2020. We are too close to those developments. Also, while I argue that India must reduce the power-gap with China if the two countries are to move to a more accommodative stance, the book does not say much else about how they should resolve their deep and growing differences. Nor is it a book that assigns blame. Holding leaders, processes, and entire societies responsible for actions and inactions is justified, even necessary, and there are writings that do so – some very partisan, others more measured and careful. This book tries to explain how India and China got to be so fractious despite their attempts at cooperation. In doing so it is probably clear enough where I attach blame even if I do not raise a red flag.

Finally, this is a work of synthesis which draws on existing scholarship. I am particularly grateful to five authors: Ranjit Singh Kalha, John Garver, Srinath Raghavan, Tansen Sen, and Reshma Patil. Anyone writing on the India–China border will profit, as I did massively, from Kalha's encyclopedic *India-China Boundary Issues: Quest for Settlement*. John Garver's massive volume, *Protracted Contest: Sino-Indian Rivalry in the Twentieth Century*, is masterful in its measured, even-handed analysis. His article 'China's Decision for War with India in 1962', published in 2006, is invaluable as a source on Chinese decision-making. Srinath Raghavan's two chapters on the India–China conflict in his *War and Peace in Modern India: A Strategic History of the Nehru Years* are fluent, rich accounts, and informed the chapter on perimeters. If it is possible to write a single volume on the history of India–China relations from the earliest times to the present, Tansen Sen's *India, China, and the World: A Connected History* has set the standard. It was never far from my reach. So also, on contemporary Chinese views of India and Indians, Reshma Patil's perceptive and often wry *Strangers Across the Border: Indian Encounters in Boomtown China* is indispensable. Time and again, I turned to these works for facts, stories, and interpretation, and I have done my best to